

MK PATNAIK

-FIRST OUTLOOK

Malla Devi Visalakshi, *47*
Visakhapatnam
Interior Designer

Constituency: Visakhapatnam

Issues that will decide her vote: Development of the people and state. Poverty eradication

Demands from the govt: Stop privatisation of Vizag Steel Plant; accord Special Category Status to Andhra; make Vizag a special railway zone

development, considering they are the beneficiaries of state-operated schemes," she says. In her own state, Visalakshi's vote will go to the YSR Congress Party because "Jagan *garu* [CM Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy] has strived towards eradicating poverty and reduced the percentage of people below the poverty line while taking care of the state's development." ■

-Amarnath K. Menon



achievements. Issues like the Ram temple in Ayodhya may be adding to the BJP's popularity but the abrogation of Article 370 has had little resonance in rural Chhattisgarh.

For the next government, which she hopes the saffron party will form, she does have a wishlist: "While the Ayushman Bharat scheme is good," she says, "implementation on the ground needs to be better." Reyman spent almost Rs 90,000 when she had her baby despite having an Ayushman card. Jobs is her other demand. "We need reservation not just for SC/ STs but also for local people in government as well as private jobs," says the sarpanch, who has studied till Class V and belongs to the Satnami community, listed as Scheduled Caste. ■

-Rahul Noronha

"While the Ayushman Bharat Yojana is good, delivery on the ground has to improve"

Don't Blame God or Modiji

Reshma Devi, *42*
Danapur, Bihar, *Fish monger*

Constituency: Patliputra

Issues that will decide her vote: Women's security, free foodgrains, Ram temple construction

Demands from the govt: Secure business or earning opportunities for the poor

Every day at 6 am, Reshma Devi sets out on an autorickshaw from her Patna suburb home, carrying two large loads of fish to the city. She spends the entire day on the footpath under a canopy umbrella, which partially shields her from the scorching sun, as she sells her catch. That gets her about Rs 400 a day.

Reshma's casual labourer husband struggles to secure steady work. She does not complain though. "It's good to work hard and earn honestly. You cannot expect God or Modiji to solve all our problems," says Reshma, who has studied till Class V and belongs to the backward Mallah caste.

Reshma lauds the Ram temple construction and the provision of 5 kg free foodgrain by the Modi government. She also acknowledges the improvement in law and order in Bihar. However, she is unaware of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's promise to provide Rs 1 lakh annually to poor women. But she disapproves of RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav for not visiting the Ram temple. ■

-Amitabh Srivastava



RANJAN RAHI